The Art of Slow Reading

In an age that rewards speed, slow reading can seem almost subversive. We skim headlines, scroll past paragraphs and mistake familiarity for understanding. Much as I sympathise with the view that time is scarce, I would argue that reading quickly often means reading nothing at all.

Slow reading is not merely reading at a lower speed. It is a deliberate practice of noticing: the choice of a verb, the rhythm of a clause, the way a writer concedes a point before overturning it.

Noticing language

Advanced learners rarely lack vocabulary in the narrow sense. What they lack is a feel for collocation and nuance. A careful reader notices that evidence is compelling rather than strong, and that a problem is tackled rather than fixed. Such details are seldom taught, yet they are precisely what distinguishes fluent writing from merely correct writing.

Not only does slow reading sharpen comprehension, but it also builds a private store of phrases that can later be borrowed and adapted.

From reading to speaking

The final step is to use what has been noticed. Reading a passage aloud reveals its rhythm: content words carry the stress, while small function words shrink and link together. Shadowing a good speaker, phrase by phrase, turns silent knowledge into something the mouth can actually produce.

Admittedly, this takes patience. Nevertheless, a single page read slowly may teach more than a whole chapter devoured in haste.